

The Faiths of Varanasi

(800 BCE–)

‘My friend, I like Banaras. It is a fine city,’ writes Mirza Ghalib to a friend in 1860. ‘I have written a poem in praise of it called *The Lamp of the Temple* [a poem of 108 stanzas in Persian],’ he adds.[1] In 1827, when Ghalib was thirty, he spent a few months in Varanasi, travelling there from Delhi on unpaved roads and boats along the Ganga. He fell in love with the mood and festive spirit of Varanasi and wrote to a friend, ‘This city is so beautiful and lovely that even a stranger misses counting his sufferings. If I would have no fear of religious contempt and criticism from my enemies, I would have left my religion . . . to count beads, bear sacred threads, put a mark on the forehead and in this way I would have passed my life on the bank of the Ganga.’

Nearly two hundred years later, in May 2019, I too make the journey from Delhi to Varanasi. I take the fastest and newest train in India, the Vande Bharat Express. Compared to Ghalib’s hard journey, mine is a lot easier, but my first response to the city is far less favourable. As on my previous visit in 2006, Varanasi strikes me as anything but lovely, with its chaotic traffic, deafening honks, poor urban planning, overcrowding, too many beggars and sporadic stench from drains. It feels left behind even by the low standards of BIMARU states. Aspiring young people have been escaping to the metros to pursue better lives. This is despite helpful recent